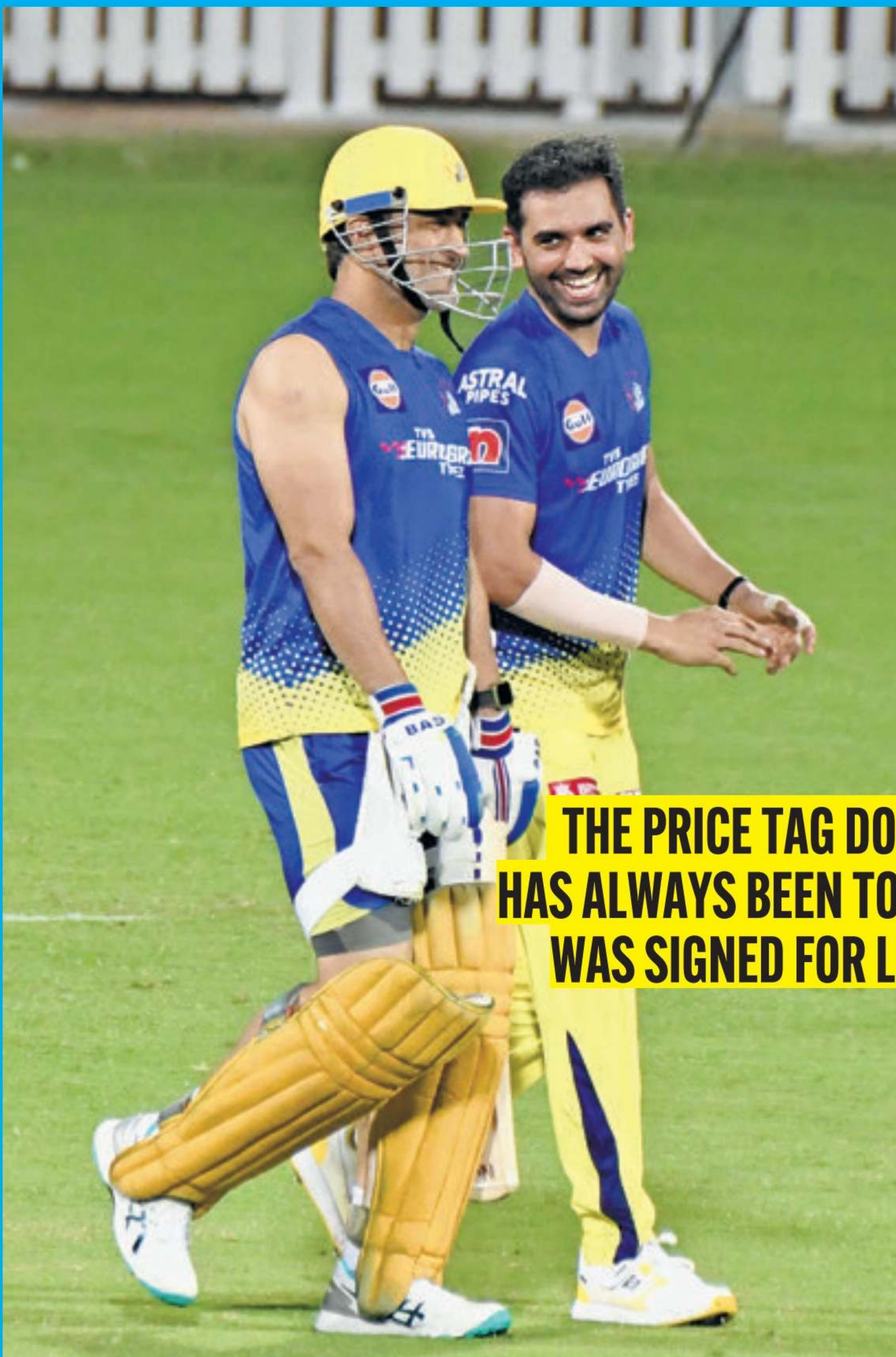




THE PRICE TAG DOESN'T MATTER. MY GOAL HAS ALWAYS BEEN TO WIN GAMES, WHETHER I WAS SIGNED FOR LESS OR FOR RS 14 CRORE WITH CSK IN 2022

All smiles: During his time with the five-time IPL champion, Deepak Chahar developed a special bond with former India and CSK captain M.S. Dhoni. R. RAGU

perform from the outset and enjoy being part of this champion side. The team is well-sorted, and I look forward to contributing.

With T20 cricket favouring batters, how do you stay motivated as a bowler?

T20 is a batter's game, but as a

bowler, the focus is on claiming wickets and containing runs. Keeping the run rate under control — below 30 runs in four overs — is a decent performance.

I take one game at a time and stay calm, which helps me execute my plans better. The pressure is often more on batters to achieve big strike rates, so I focus on doing my job efficiently. It's always a challenge to keep the strike rate revolving around 150 to 180. That's how I look at it.

How do you view the competition among Indian fast bowlers, given

your history with injuries?

Fitness has been my only concern, not performance. I've always delivered with bat and ball for India whenever I've played (16 wickets in 13 ODIs and 31 wickets in 25 T20Is; 203 runs in nine ODI innings with the bat and 53 runs in seven T20I innings). Now that I have played all the league games of the Ranji Trophy so far and am also playing the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy for Rajasthan this season, I am finding my rhythm.

I don't worry much about competition. The skill set I bring — swing bowling with the new ball and batting (**facing page, below**) at No. 8 — isn't very common. If I remain fit and consistent, I'm confident of earning another opportunity with the national team.

You went to England to work on your fitness after last IPL. Could you share your experience?

After IPL, I trained in the UK with a top football club for 12 weeks, focusing on improving my lower-body strength, which has been a concern in the past.

The training helped me prepare for the Ranji Trophy while also focusing on bowling consistently. The experience was invaluable in regaining rhythm and readiness for switching formats during the season.

Comebacks after injuries are challenging. How do you stay motivated?

Sport is about mental toughness and bouncing back from setbacks. I've had injuries throughout my career, but I've followed the process and returned every time.

Instead of overthinking injuries, I